Decision-outcome dry run (v0.6-dry): does the reply leave the traveler informed?

24 Oct 2026 · separate version, never pooled with v0.5

This is a method check with AI readers, not human evidence. Its job is to test whether the decision-outcome test works before running it with people, and to see early what it shows.

1. Why

The v0.5 judges score whether a reply *contains* the protocol's items, and some metrics echo the protocol's own wording. The review asked for an outcome measure that doesn't mirror the rubric: after reading the reply, can the traveler say what they would gain or lose?

2. How it worked

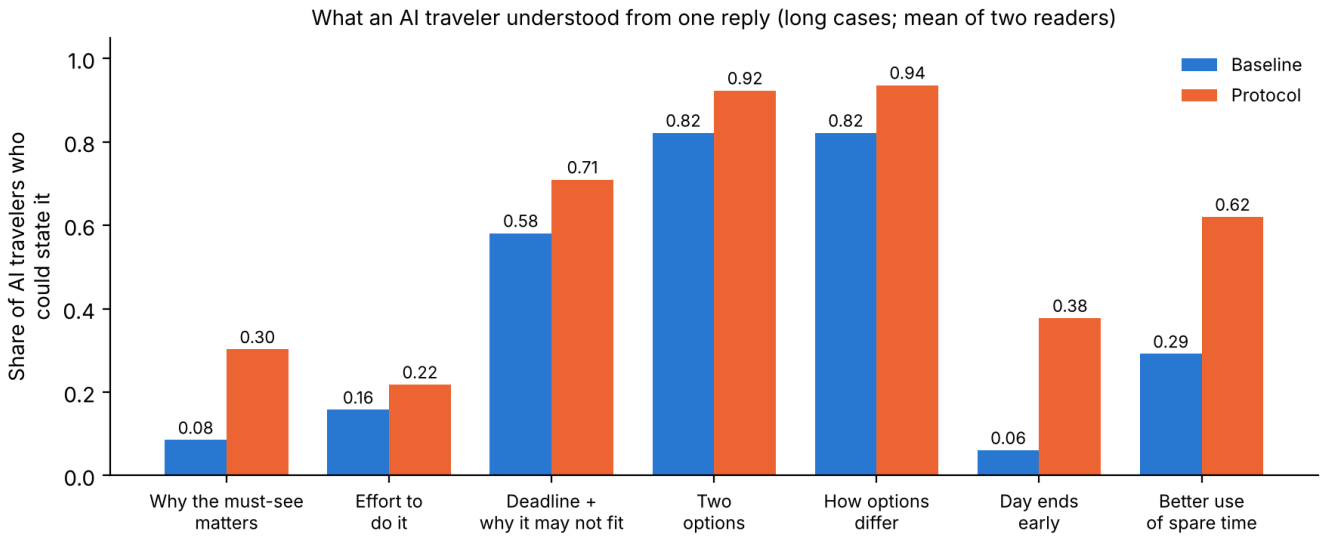
1. **Reader.** An AI "traveler" sees only its own message and the assistant's reply (★ markers removed, no earlier history). It answers generic questions that never use the protocol's words: - What choices do you now have, and what do you gain or give up with each? - Is anything time-sensitive? - Does this reply make you want to reopen something you'd already decided?

Two reader models from different families ran separately: GPT-6 Luna and Gemini 3.5 Flash-Lite. 2. **Grader.** A third model (Claude Haiku 5.5) checked the reader's answer against the case's gold points. It saw only the reader's summary, never the reply.

Decision point	Gold points
★ day and approach	why the must-see matters; the effort to do it
Deadline	the deadline, and why the booking may no longer fit
Booking	two options; how they differ
Final day	the day ends early; a better use of the time
3. **Sample.** Baseline vs protocol only, on paired cells (both arms produced a usable reply):	
- long triggered cases DP1–DP5: 418 replies;	
- all controls: 266 replies.	

Parse failures were 0.4% of readings and 0.6% of gradings.

3. Results



3.1 Travelers understood more after protocol replies, but the gain is smaller than the judges reported.

Measure (long triggered cases)	Baseline	Protocol	P − B (95% CI)	Cases positive
Points recovered, reader GPT-6 Luna	0.44	0.62	+0.18 (0.13, 0.23)	6/6
Points recovered, reader Gemini Flash-Lite	0.40	0.56	+0.16 (0.10, 0.23)	6/6
Mean of both readers	**0.42**	**0.59**	**+0.17 (0.12, 0.23)**	**6/6**, exact p = 0.031
For comparison: v0.5 judge composite	*0.49*	*0.76*	*+0.27 (0.19, 0.35)*	*6/6*

The two readers agreed closely (κ = 0.80 on individual points), so the measure is stable across reader models.

3.2 Where the understanding came from:

- **Deadline:** 58% → 71% of travelers knew the deadline and why the booking might not fit (+0.13, both readers, 6/6 cases).
- **Spare time:** 6% → 38% realised the day would end early, and 29% → 62% knew a better use of the time. This is the largest gain.
- **The must-see:** only 8% → 30% could say *why* it mattered, and the effort barely moved (16% → 22%). Even with the protocol, most travelers didn't come away knowing what the must-see was worth.
- **Options:** both arms usually gave two options (82% → 92%), so the gain here was small.

3.3 Which judge labels hold up. We compared each judge label with whether the reader recovered the same points.

Judge field	Agreement with readers (κ)	Reading
Deadline recall (DR)	0.90–0.97	**Confirmed.** Judges and readers almost always agree.
Idle-time flag (ISD)	0.51–0.66	Reasonable
Option comparison (AoC)	0.48–0.58	Moderate. Readers credit options more often than judges do.

Judge field	Agreement with readers (κ)	Reading
Signature coverage (SCD)	0.27–0.29	**Weak.** Judges said 35% of replies covered the must-see properly; readers recovered it from only 9–10%.

So the judges likely **overstate** must-see coverage. When a reply mentions the item in passing, judges credit it, but travelers don't take the point away.

3.4 Controls: the over-intervention cost did not show up as "reopening".

Reader	Wants to reopen a settled decision: Baseline	Protocol	P − B (95% CI)	Cases positive (of 9)
GPT-6 Luna	20%	21%	+0.03 (0.00, 0.08)	2
Gemini Flash-Lite	9%	16%	+0.04 (−0.03, 0.12)	3
v0.5 judges, OVER = 2	*10%*	*26%*	*+0.16*	

Readers did want to reopen decisions more often after replies the judges flagged as over-intervening (32–38% vs 8–16%), so the two measures point the same way, but their agreement is low (κ 0.21–0.27). Either the judges overstate the cost, or "wanting to reopen" is narrower than over-intervention: an unrequested audit can be annoying without making anyone change plans. Humans need to settle this.

4. What this means for the paper

1. **The main result survives a non-echo test**, at a smaller size: +0.17 instead of +0.27, and still positive in all six cases. The gap is roughly the share of the judge effect that is rubric echo.
2. **The deadline result is the most solid finding:** judges and readers agree almost perfectly.
3. **The must-see result is weaker than the judges said.** The protocol makes models mention the must-see but rarely makes its value land. This argues for a protocol change: lead with the value in one plain sentence.
4. **The over-intervention cost is now in doubt.** It may be smaller than the judges' +0.16. That makes the human labels for that field more important, not less.

5. Caveats

- **AI readers aren't people.** They read every word, they may be more literal than a busy traveler, and they share training with the assistants.
- **The grader is lenient in places.** For example, it sometimes credited the deadline point without the dependency, and it is itself an AI.
- **Readers saw only the current reply.** Information given in an earlier turn of the same conversation doesn't count. This is deliberate (the question is what the decision-time reply conveys), but it is strict.
- **"Reopen" is not the same construct as over-intervention.**
- **Scale is the same as v0.5:** 6 long cases and one trial.

6. Next step

Run the same test with people:

- 40–60 readers, each shown about 10 replies from the same paired cells;
- the same questions, graded by two human coders;
- for controls, add "Was this reply more than you needed?"

Files: `scoring/reader_dryrun_v06.py`, `scoring/analysis_dryrun_v06.py`, `outputs/dryrun_v06/`, `outputs/analysis_dryrun_v06/analysis.json`.